

READING 86

BASICS OF PORTFOLIO PLANNING AND CONSTRUCTION

MODULE 86.1: PORTFOLIO PLANNING AND CONSTRUCTION



Video covering this content is available online.

LOS 86.a: Describe the reasons for a written investment policy statement (IPS).

An investment manager is very unlikely to produce a good result for a client without understanding that client's needs, circumstances, and constraints.

A written **investment policy statement** will typically begin with the investor's goals in terms of risk and return. These should be determined jointly, as the goals of high returns and low risk (while quite popular) are likely to be mutually exclusive in practice. Investor expectations in terms of returns must be compatible with investor's tolerance for risk (uncertainty about portfolio performance).

LOS 86.b: Describe the major components of an IPS.

The major components of an IPS typically address the following:

- *Description of Client* circumstances, situation, and investment objectives.
- *Statement of the Purpose* of the IPS.
- *Statement of Duties and Responsibilities* of investment manager, custodian of assets, and the client.
- *Procedures* to update IPS and to respond to various possible situations.
- *Investment Objectives* derived from communications with the client.
- *Investment Constraints* that must be considered in the plan.
- *Investment Guidelines* such as how the policy will be executed, asset types permitted, and leverage to be used.
- *Evaluation of Performance*, the benchmark portfolio for evaluating investment performance, and other information on evaluation of investment results.
- *Appendices* containing information on strategic (baseline) asset allocation and permitted deviations from policy portfolio allocations, as well as how and when the

portfolio allocations should be rebalanced.

In any case, the IPS will, at a minimum, contain a clear statement of client circumstances and constraints, an investment strategy based on these, and some benchmark against which to evaluate the account performance.

LOS 86.c: Describe risk and return objectives and how they may be developed for a client.

The **risk objectives** in an IPS may take several forms. An **absolute risk objective** might be to “have no decrease in portfolio value during any 12-month period” or to “not decrease in value by more than 2% at any point over any 12-month period.” Low absolute percentage risk objectives such as these may result in portfolios made up of securities that offer guaranteed returns (e.g., U.S. Treasury bills).

Absolute risk objectives can also be stated in terms of the probability of specific portfolio results, either percentage losses or dollar losses, rather than strict limits on portfolio results. Examples are as follows:

- “No greater than a 5% probability of returns below –5% in any 12-month period.”
- “No greater than a 4% probability of a loss of more than \$20,000 over any 12-month period.”

An absolute return objective may be stated in nominal terms, such as “an overall return of at least 6% per annum,” or in real returns, such as “a return of 3% more than the annual inflation rate each year.”

Relative risk objectives relate to a specific benchmark and can also be strict, such as, “Returns will not be less than 12-month euro LIBOR over any 12-month period,” or stated in terms of probability, such as, “No greater than a 5% probability of returns more than 4% below the return on the MSCI World Index over any 12-month period.”

Return objectives can be relative to a benchmark portfolio return, such as, “Exceed the return on the S&P 500 Index by 2% per annum.” For a bank, the return objective may be relative to the bank’s cost of funds (deposit rate). While it is possible for an institution to use returns on peer portfolios, such as an endowment with a stated objective to be in the top quartile of endowment fund returns, peer performance benchmarks suffer from not being *investable* portfolios. There is no way to match this investment return by portfolio construction before the fact.

In any event, the account manager must make sure that the stated risk and return objectives are compatible, given the reality of expected investment results and uncertainty over time.

LOS 86.d: Explain the difference between the willingness and the ability (capacity) to take risk in analyzing an investor’s financial risk tolerance.

An investor’s **ability to bear risk** depends on financial circumstances. Longer investment horizons (20 years rather than 2 years), greater assets versus liabilities

(more wealth), more insurance against unexpected occurrences, and a secure job all suggest a greater ability to bear investment risk in terms of uncertainty about periodic investment performance.

An investor's **willingness to bear risk** is based primarily on the investor's attitudes and beliefs about investments (various asset types). The assessment of an investor's attitude about risk is quite subjective and is sometimes done with a short questionnaire that attempts to categorize the investor's risk aversion or risk tolerance.

When the adviser's assessments of an investor's ability and willingness to take investment risk are compatible, there is no real problem selecting an appropriate level of investment risk. If the investor's willingness to take on investment risk is high but the investor's ability to take on risk is low, the low ability to take on investment risk will prevail in the adviser's assessment.

In situations where ability is high but willingness is low, the adviser may attempt to educate the investor about investment risk and correct any misconceptions that may be contributing to the investor's low stated willingness to take on investment risk. However, the adviser's job is not to change the investor's personality characteristics that contribute to a low willingness to take on investment risk. The approach will most likely be to conform to the lower of the investor's ability or willingness to bear risk, as constructing a portfolio with a level of risk that the client is clearly uncomfortable with will not likely lead to a good outcome in the investor's view.

LOS 86.e: Describe the investment constraints of liquidity, time horizon, tax concerns, legal and regulatory factors, and unique circumstances and their implications for the choice of portfolio assets.



PROFESSOR'S NOTE

When some of us were studying for the CFA exams over 20 years ago, we memorized R-R-T-T-L-L-U as a checklist for addressing the important points of portfolio construction, and it still works today. Then, as now, the important points to cover in an IPS were Risk, Return, Time horizon, Tax situation, Liquidity, Legal restrictions, and the Unique constraints of a specific investor.

Investment constraints include the investor's liquidity needs, time horizon, tax considerations, legal and regulatory constraints, and unique needs and preferences.

Liquidity: Liquidity refers to the ability to turn investment assets into spendable cash in a short period of time without having to make significant price concessions to do so. Investor needs for money to pay tuition, to pay for a parent's assisted living expenses, or to fund other possible spending needs may all require that some liquid assets be held. As we noted in an earlier reading discussing property and casualty insurance companies, claims arrive unpredictably to some extent and therefore their portfolios must hold a significant proportion of liquid (or maturing) securities in order to be prepared to honor these claims. Illiquid investments in hedge funds and private equity funds, which typically are not traded and have restrictions on redemptions, are not suitable for an investor who may unexpectedly need access to the funds.

Time horizon: In general, the longer an investor's time horizon, the more risk and less liquidity the investor can accept in the portfolio. While the expected returns on a broad equities portfolio may not be too risky for an investor with a 20-year investment horizon, they likely are too risky for an investor who must fund a large purchase at the end of this year. For such an investor, government securities or a bank certificate of deposit may be the most appropriate investments because of their low risk and high liquidity at the time when the funds will be needed.

Tax situation: Besides an individual's overall tax rate, the tax treatment of various types of investment accounts is also a consideration in portfolio construction. For a fully taxable account, investors subject to higher tax rates may prefer tax-free bonds (U.S.) to taxable bonds or prefer equities that are expected to produce capital gains, which are often taxed at a lower rate than other types of income. A focus on expected after-tax returns over time in relation to risk should correctly account for differences in tax treatments as well as investors' overall tax rates.

Some types of investment accounts, such as retirement accounts, may be tax exempt or tax deferred. Investors with such accounts may choose to put securities that generate fully taxed income, such as corporate bond interest, in accounts that are tax deferred, while seeking long-term capital gains, tax-exempt interest income, and dividend income (in jurisdictions where dividends receive preferential tax treatment) in their personal accounts, which have no tax deferral benefit.

Legal and regulatory: In addition to financial market regulations that apply to all investors, more specific legal and regulatory constraints may apply to particular investors. Trust, corporate, and qualified investment accounts may all be restricted by law from investing in particular types of securities and assets. There may also be restrictions on percentage allocations to specific types of investments in such accounts. Corporate officers and directors face legal restrictions on trading in the securities of their firms that the account manager should be aware of.

Unique circumstances: Each investor, whether individual or institutional, may have specific preferences or restrictions on which securities and assets may be purchased for the account. Some of these may be nonfinancial considerations, which are commonly categorized as **responsible investing**. Ethical preferences, such as prohibiting investment in securities issued by tobacco or firearms producers, are not uncommon. Restrictions on investments in companies or countries where human rights abuses are suspected or documented would also fall into this category. Religious preferences may preclude investment in securities that make explicit interest payments.

Unique investor preferences may also be based on diversification needs when the investor's income depends heavily on the prospects for one company or industry. An investor who has founded or runs a company may not want any investment in securities issued by a competitor to that company.

LOS 86.f: Explain the specification of asset classes in relation to asset allocation.

After having determined the investor objectives and constraints through the exercise of creating an IPS, a **strategic asset allocation** is developed which specifies the percentage allocations to the included asset classes. In choosing which asset classes to consider when developing the strategic asset allocation for the account, the correlations of returns *within* an asset class should be relatively high, indicating that the assets within the class are similar in their investment performance. On the other hand, it is low correlations of returns *between* asset classes that leads to risk reduction through portfolio diversification.

Historically, only the broad categories of equities, bonds, cash, and real estate were considered. More recently, a group of several investable asset classes, referred to collectively as alternative investments, has gained more prominence. Alternative investment asset classes include hedge funds of various types, private equity funds, managed or passively constructed commodity funds, artwork, and intellectual property rights.

We can further divide equities by whether the issuing companies are domestic or foreign, large or small, or whether they are traded in emerging or developed markets. An example of specifying asset classes is world equities. A U.S. investor may want to divide world equities into different regions.

With bonds, we can divide the overall universe of bonds into asset classes based on maturities or on criteria such as whether they are foreign or domestic, government or corporate, or investment grade or speculative (high yield). Overall, the asset classes considered should approximate the universe of permissible investments specified in the IPS.

Once the universe of asset classes has been specified, the investment manager will collect data on the returns, standard deviation of returns, and correlations of returns with those of other asset classes for each asset class.

Figure 86.1 illustrates the strategic asset allocation for a pension fund.

Figure 86.1: Strategic Asset Allocation

The Vermont Pension Investment Committee manages more than \$4 billion in retirement assets for various teachers and state and municipal employees in that state. VPIC's investment policy specifies the following strategic asset allocation:

Asset Class	Target
Growth assets	
Passive global equities	24%
Active global equities	5%
Large cap U.S. equities	4%
Small-/mid-cap U.S. equities	3%
Non-U.S. developed market equities	5%
International small-cap equities	2%
Private equity	10%
Core plus fixed income	6%
Emerging market debt	4%
Private debt	5%
Non-core real estate	3%
Total growth assets	71%
Downturn hedging assets	
Core fixed income	14%
Short-term quality credit	5%
Total downturn hedging	19%
Inflation hedging assets	
Core real estate	5%
U.S. TIPS	3%
Infrastructure/farmland	2%
Total inflation hedging	10%

Source: State of Vermont, Office of the State Treasurer.
Target allocation as of March 25, 2019.
www.vermonttreasurer.gov/content/pension.

LOS 86.g: Describe the principles of portfolio construction and the role of asset allocation in relation to the IPS.

Once the portfolio manager has identified the investable asset classes for the portfolio and the risk, return, and correlation characteristics of each asset class, an *efficient frontier*, analogous to one constructed from individual securities, can be constructed using a computer program. By combining the return and risk objectives from the IPS with the actual risk and return properties of the many portfolios along the efficient frontier, the manager can identify that portfolio which best meets the risk and return requirements of the investor. The asset allocation for the efficient portfolio selected is then the strategic asset allocation for the portfolio.

So far, we have not concerned ourselves with deviations from strategic asset allocations or with selection of individual securities within individual asset classes. These activities are referred to as active (versus passive) portfolio management strategies. A manager who varies from strategic asset allocation weights in order to take advantage

of perceived short-term opportunities is adding **tactical asset allocation** to the portfolio strategy. **Security selection** refers to deviations from index weights on individual securities within an asset class. For example, a portfolio manager might overweight energy stocks and underweight financial stocks, relative to the index weights for U.S. large-cap equities as an asset class. For some asset classes, such as hedge funds, individual real estate properties, and artwork, investable indexes are not available. For these asset classes, selection of individual assets is required by the nature of the asset class.

While each of these active strategies may produce higher returns, they each also increase the risk of the portfolio compared to a passive portfolio of asset class indexes. A practice known as **risk budgeting** sets an overall risk limit for the portfolio and budgets (allocates) a portion of the permitted risk to the systematic risk of the strategic asset allocation, the risk from tactical asset allocation, and the risk from security selection.

Active portfolio management has two specific issues to consider.

1. An investor may have multiple managers actively managing to the same benchmark for the same asset class (or may have significant benchmark overlap). In this case, one manager may overweight an index stock while another may underweight the same stock. Taken together, there is no net active management risk, although each manager has reported active management risk. Overall, the risk budget is underutilized as there is less net active management than gross active management.
2. When all managers are actively managing portfolios relative to an index, trading may be excessive overall. This extra trading could have negative tax consequences, specifically potentially higher capital gains taxes, compared to an overall efficient tax strategy.

One way to address these issues is to use a **core-satellite approach**. The core-satellite approach invests the majority, or core, portion of the portfolio in passively managed indexes and invests a smaller, or satellite, portion in active strategies. This approach reduces the likelihood of excessive trading and offsetting active positions.

Clearly, the success of security selection will depend on the manager's skill and the opportunities (mispricings or inefficiencies) within a particular asset class. Similarly, the success of tactical asset allocation will depend both on the existence of short-term opportunities in specific asset classes and on the manager's ability to identify them.

LOS 86.h: Describe how environmental, social, and governance (ESG) considerations may be integrated into portfolio planning and construction.

Approaches to ESG investing include:

- **Negative screening**, excluding specific companies or industries based on ESG factors.
- **Positive screening**, investing in companies that have positive ESG practices.
- **Thematic investing**, selecting sectors or companies to promote specific ESG-related goals.

- **Impact investing**, selecting investments both to provide a return and to promote positive ESG practices.
- **Engagement/active ownership**, using share ownership as a platform to promote improved ESG practices at a company.
- **ESG integration**, considering ESG factors throughout the asset allocation and security selection process.

If a portfolio's investment universe is constrained by negative screening, measuring its performance against a broad market index is unlikely to be appropriate. Indexes excluding companies or industries that investors with ESG concerns commonly avoid are available.

While many investors use positive screening, thematic, or impact investing approaches, choices of which specific companies to invest in and which ESG factors to focus on differ among investors. Thus, portfolios and performance benchmarks must be customized under these approaches, and they may require investment managers who specialize in these styles of investing.

For investment managers with clients who wish to engage in active ownership, it is important to clarify whether the clients intend to vote their shares themselves or direct the managers to vote the shares according to specified ESG factors.

Regardless of the approach chosen, investors should be aware that imposing constraints based on ESG factors will likely affect portfolio performance. How these constraints will affect portfolio performance in practice is uncertain. Both limiting the universe of investment choices and incurring the costs involved in considering ESG factors may decrease returns. On the other hand, investing in companies with good corporate governance practices and avoiding those that face ESG-related risks may increase portfolio returns.



MODULE QUIZ 86.1

1. The investment policy statement is *most accurately* considered the:
 - A. starting point of the portfolio management process.
 - B. key intermediate step in the portfolio management process.
 - C. end product of the portfolio management process.
2. The component of an investment policy statement that defines the investment objectives is *most likely* to include information about:
 - A. the investor's risk tolerance.
 - B. unique needs and preferences of the investor.
 - C. permitted asset types and use of leverage in the investment account.
3. When an investment advisor is developing return and risk objectives for a client:
 - A. return objectives should be absolute and risk objectives should be relative.
 - B. risk objectives should be absolute and return objectives should be relative.
 - C. both return and risk objectives may be stated in absolute or relative terms.
4. A client exhibits an above-average willingness to take risk but a below-average ability to take risk. When assigning an overall risk tolerance, the investment adviser is *most likely* to assess the client's overall risk tolerance as:
 - A. above average.

- B. average.
 - C. below average.
5. Which of the following is *least likely* an example of a portfolio constraint?
- A. Higher tax rate on dividend income than on capital gains.
 - B. Significant spending requirements in the near future.
 - C. Minimum total return requirement of 8%.
6. For asset allocation purposes, asset classes should be specified such that correlations of returns are relatively:
- A. low within each asset class and low among asset classes.
 - B. high within each asset class and low among asset classes.
 - C. low within each asset class and high among asset classes.
7. In determining the appropriate asset allocation for a client's investment account, the manager should:
- A. consider only the investor's risk tolerance.
 - B. incorporate forecasts of future economic conditions.
 - C. consider the investor's risk tolerance and future needs, but not forecasts of market conditions.

KEY CONCEPTS

LOS 86.a

A written investment policy statement, the first step in the portfolio management process, is a plan for achieving investment success. An IPS forces investment discipline and ensures that goals are realistic by requiring investors to articulate their circumstances, objectives, and constraints.

LOS 86.b

Many IPS include the following sections:

- Introduction—Describes the client.
- Statement of Purpose—The intentions of the IPS.
- Statement of Duties and Responsibilities—Of the client, the asset custodian, and the investment managers.
- Procedures—Related to keeping the IPS updated and responding to unforeseen events.
- Investment Objectives—The client's investment needs, specified in terms of required return and risk tolerance.
- Investment Constraints—Factors that may hinder the ability to meet investment objectives; typically categorized as time horizon, taxes, liquidity, legal and regulatory, and unique needs.
- Investment Guidelines—For example, whether leverage, derivatives, or specific kinds of assets are allowed.
- Evaluation and Review—Related to feedback on investment results.
- Appendices—May specify the portfolio's strategic asset allocation (policy portfolio) or the portfolio's rebalancing policy.

LOS 86.c

Risk objectives are specifications for portfolio risk that are developed to embody a client's risk tolerance. Risk objectives can be either absolute (e.g., no losses greater than 10% in any year) or relative (e.g., annual return will be within 2% of FTSE return).

Return objectives are typically based on an investor's desire to meet a future financial goal, such as a particular level of income in retirement. Return objectives can be absolute (e.g., 9% annual return) or relative (e.g., outperform the S&P 500 by 2% per year).

The achievability of an investor's return expectations may be hindered by the investor's risk objectives.

LOS 86.d

Willingness to take financial risk is related to an investor's psychological factors, such as personality type and level of financial knowledge.

Ability or capacity to take risk depends on financial factors, such as wealth relative to liabilities, income stability, and time horizon.

A client's overall risk tolerance depends on both his ability to take risk and his willingness to take risk. A willingness greater than ability, or vice versa, is typically resolved by choosing the more conservative of the two and counseling the client.

LOS 86.e

Investment constraints include:

- Liquidity—The need to draw cash from the portfolio for anticipated or unexpected future spending needs. High liquidity needs often translate to a high portfolio allocation to bonds or cash.
- Time horizon—Often the period over which assets are accumulated and before withdrawals begin. Risky or illiquid investments may be inappropriate for an investor with a short time horizon.
- Tax considerations—Concerns the tax treatments of the investor's various accounts, the relative tax treatment of capital gains and income, and the investor's marginal tax bracket.
- Legal and regulatory—Constraints such as government restrictions on portfolio contents or laws against insider trading.
- Unique circumstances—Restrictions due to investor preferences (religious, ethical, etc.) or other factors not already considered.

LOS 86.f

An asset class is a group of securities with similar risk and performance characteristics. Examples of major asset classes include equity, fixed income, cash, and real estate. Portfolio managers also use more narrowly defined asset classes, such as large-cap U.S. equities or speculative international bonds, and alternative asset classes, such as commodities or investments in hedge funds.

LOS 86.g

Strategic asset allocation is a set of percentage allocations to various asset classes that is designed to meet the investor's objectives. The strategic asset allocation is developed by combining the objectives and constraints in the IPS with the performance expectations of the various asset classes. The strategic asset allocation provides the basic structure of a portfolio.

Tactical asset allocation refers to an allocation that deviates from the baseline (strategic) allocation in order to profit from a forecast of shorter-term opportunities in specific asset classes.

LOS 86.h

Imposing portfolio constraints based on ESG factors may affect performance. Limiting the universe of investment choices may decrease returns, but good corporate governance and low ESG-related risks may increase returns.

If a portfolio's investment universe is constrained by negative screening, its performance should be measured against a benchmark that excludes companies with negative ESG factors.

Positive screening, best-in-class, or thematic investing approaches typically require portfolio construction to be customized for the investor's choices of which ESG factors to focus on.

For active ownership, it is important to clarify whether investors intend to vote their shares themselves or direct managers to vote the shares according to specified ESG factors.

ANSWER KEY FOR MODULE QUIZZES

Module Quiz 86.1

1. **A** An investment policy statement is considered to be the starting point of the portfolio management process. The IPS is a plan for achieving investment success. (LOS 86.a)
2. **A** Investment objectives are defined based on both the investor's return requirements and risk tolerance. Investment constraints include the investor's time horizon, liquidity needs, tax considerations, legal and regulatory requirements, and unique needs and preferences. Policies regarding permitted asset types and the amount of leverage to use are best characterized as investment guidelines. (LOS 86.b)
3. **C** Both risk and return objectives can be defined either in absolute terms or relative to some benchmark. (LOS 86.c)
4. **C** When assigning an overall risk tolerance, the prudent approach is to use the lower of ability to take risk and willingness to take risk. (LOS 86.d)

- 5. **C** Return objectives are part of a policy statement's objectives, not constraints. (LOS 86.e)
- 6. **B** Asset classes should be defined such that correlations of returns within the asset class are relatively high (because assets within a class should perform alike over time), while correlations of returns among asset classes are relatively low (to benefit from diversification). (LOS 86.f)
- 7. **B** An adviser's forecasts of the expected returns and expected volatilities (risk) of different asset classes are an important part of determining an appropriate asset allocation. (LOS 86.g)